

# The Romantic Movement

The art movement known as Romanticism revolutionized art and philosophy in the late 18th century and the period that followed. Elevating the importance of self-expression, intuition, emotion, and the imagination over reason, Romanticism saw the beginning of the distinction between art and science.



## BEFORE

Before Romanticism, Enlightenment thinkers sought answers to profound questions in science and reason. Romanticism challenged this.

### CLASSICISM

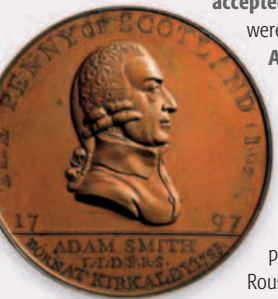
The Classical art movement of the Renaissance << 250–53 imitated that of the ancient Greeks and Romans << 116–17, which was characterized by **precision, elegance, and simplicity**. Classicists followed the formal rules of art set down by ancient cultures.

### THE ENLIGHTENMENT

The Enlightenment << 270–71 spread a spirit of inquiry across Europe and its colonies during the 18th century. **Valuing reason, science, and progress**, its ethos was summarized by the English poet Alexander Pope: “Nature, and Nature’s laws lay hid in night: God said, Let Newton be! and all was light.” Inspired by Isaac Newton’s << 267 scientific inquiry into the world, Enlightenment thinkers had a thirst for knowledge that coincided with a **period of great scientific discovery and exploration**.

### CHALLENGING IDEAS

French philosopher René Descartes advocated **doubting everything** until rational grounds had been established for believing it, which led enlightened thinkers to **challenge previously accepted truths**. Among them were Scottish economist **Adam Smith** (left), whose *Inquiry into the Nature and Causes of the Wealth of Nations* revolutionized economics and social thinking, and the French philosopher Jean-Jacques Rousseau, whose works were an inspiration for the French Revolution << 302–303.



ADAM SMITH

### THE ROLE OF ART

Until Romanticism the word “art” was synonymous with “craftsmanship,” and the word “artist” was used interchangeably with “artisan.” Craftworker-painters were connected to the courtly, religious, and corporate institutions in society, and the nature of their art was guided by the patron, who funded and commissioned the work, rather than the artists themselves.



### “The Little Girl Lost”

This illustrated poem is part of *Songs of Experience*, a poetic collection written and illustrated by the English Romantic poet and engraver William Blake. Its celebration of emotion and imagination is typical of Romantic poetry.

Romanticism gave Germans a sense of national unity at a time when “Germany” was little more than a fragmented group of states. Led by Johann Wolfgang von Goethe (see below) with his novel *The Sorrows of Young Werther*, German writers and poets advocated *sturm und drang* (“storm and stress”), flouting convention by rebelling against their rational educations and emphasizing emotion in their work.

The German pioneers also established other motifs that would become characteristic of the movement. These included a respect for traditional folk art and customs, a sense of wonder at the marvels of nature, and an enthusiasm for ancient mystical and pagan beliefs. Above all, emotion was considered

**“Romanticism is... neither in choice of subject nor exact truth, but in a way of feeling.”**

CHARLES BAUDELAIRE, FRENCH POET, “THE SALON OF 1846,” 1846

### GERMAN WRITER AND THINKER (1749–1832)

#### JOHANN WOLFGANG VON GOETHE

Goethe was a major inspiration for the Romantic movement, of which he eventually came to disapprove. In 1773 he wrote the archetypal Romantic drama *Gotz von Berlichingen*, about a young genius rebelling against the conventions of society. He went on to create more misunderstood heroes, but Goethe’s masterpiece was the classically-influenced *Faust*, a reworking of the tale of a disillusioned scholar who sells his soul to Satan.



superior to reason. This led to the cult of the artist as hero, capable of expressing thoughts and feelings beyond the realms of ordinary people.

### Art for art’s sake

The Romantic ideal was that art should be a form of self-expression rather than a commodity, and that artists should not be treated as hired hands. Painters began to distance themselves from their craft-based heritage and increasingly art became an imaginative product rather than merely a possession of the artist’s patron. This reinforced the Romantic idea of the artist as a gifted individual, intrinsically different from “ordinary” people—a status indulged to its fullest by the English poet Lord Byron, and the German composers Ludwig van Beethoven and Richard Wagner.

Many painters abandoned the strict rules of classicism and instead brought personal significance to their work. Epitomized by the work of William